



Personality *is* a person-specific complex, nonlinear dynamic system

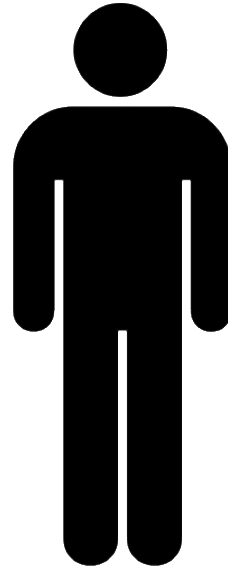
Emorie D. Beck, Ph.D.
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beck-lab.ucdavis.edu



Description

Prediction

Explanation



Thoughts

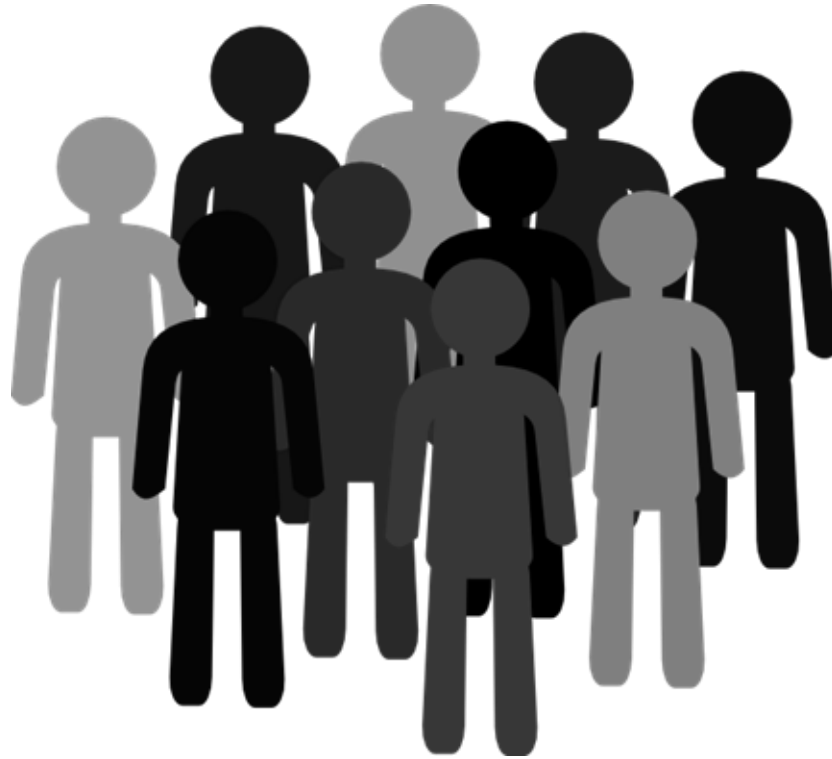
Feelings

Behaviors

Description

Prediction

Explanation



Thoughts

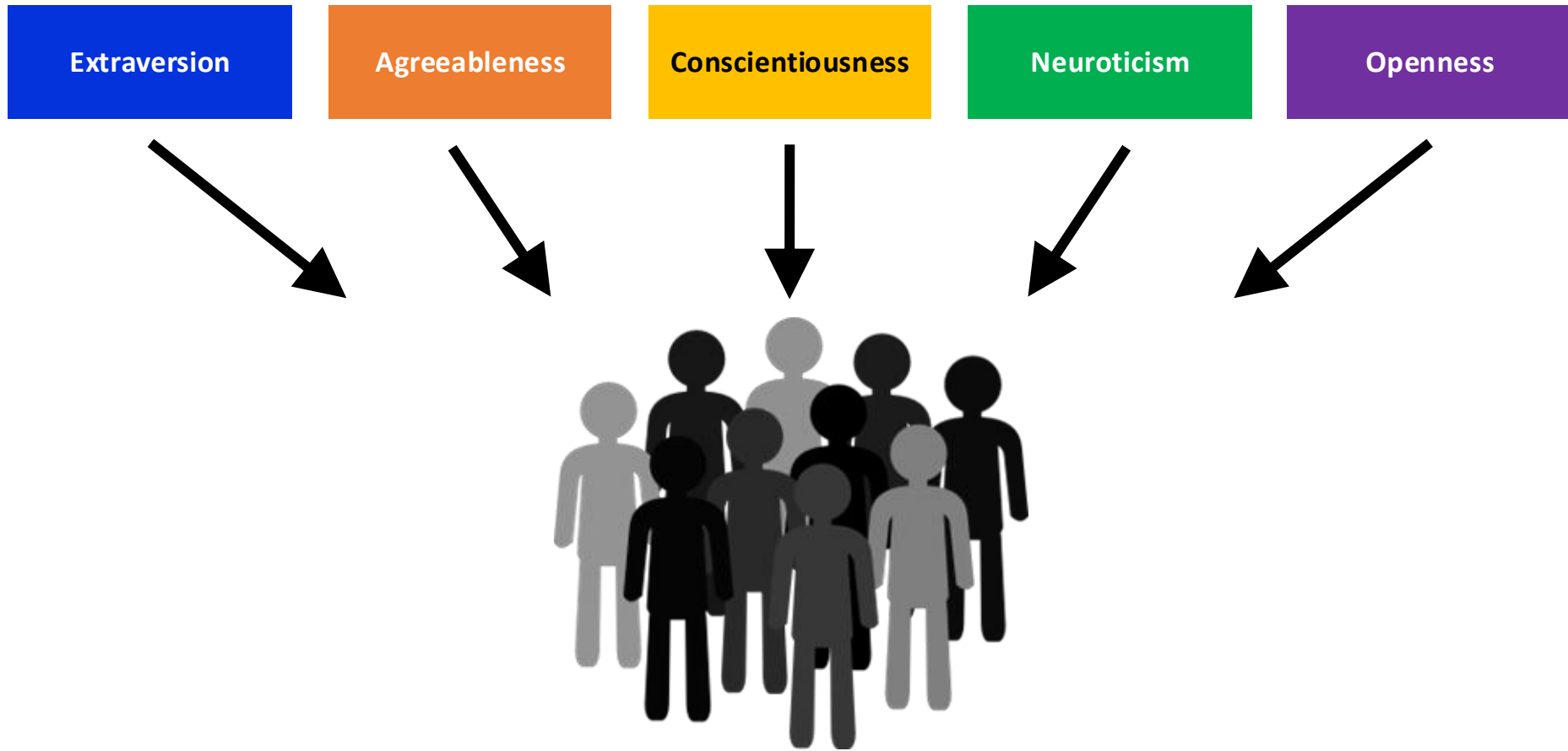
Feelings

Behaviors

What is personality?

“Personality refers to those **characteristics** of the person that account for **consistent patterns of feelings, thinking, and behaving.**”

(Pervin, Cervone & John, 2005, p. 6)



**Population-Level
Between-Person
Variable-Centered**



EJP
@EJPBlog

...

"We assessed personality with the Big Five - As seductive as it is to make such statements, they are only a bit true... personality is not just the Big Five." Read [@rauthmann](#) blog post and memes here. [ejp-blog.com/blog/2024/9/17...](#)

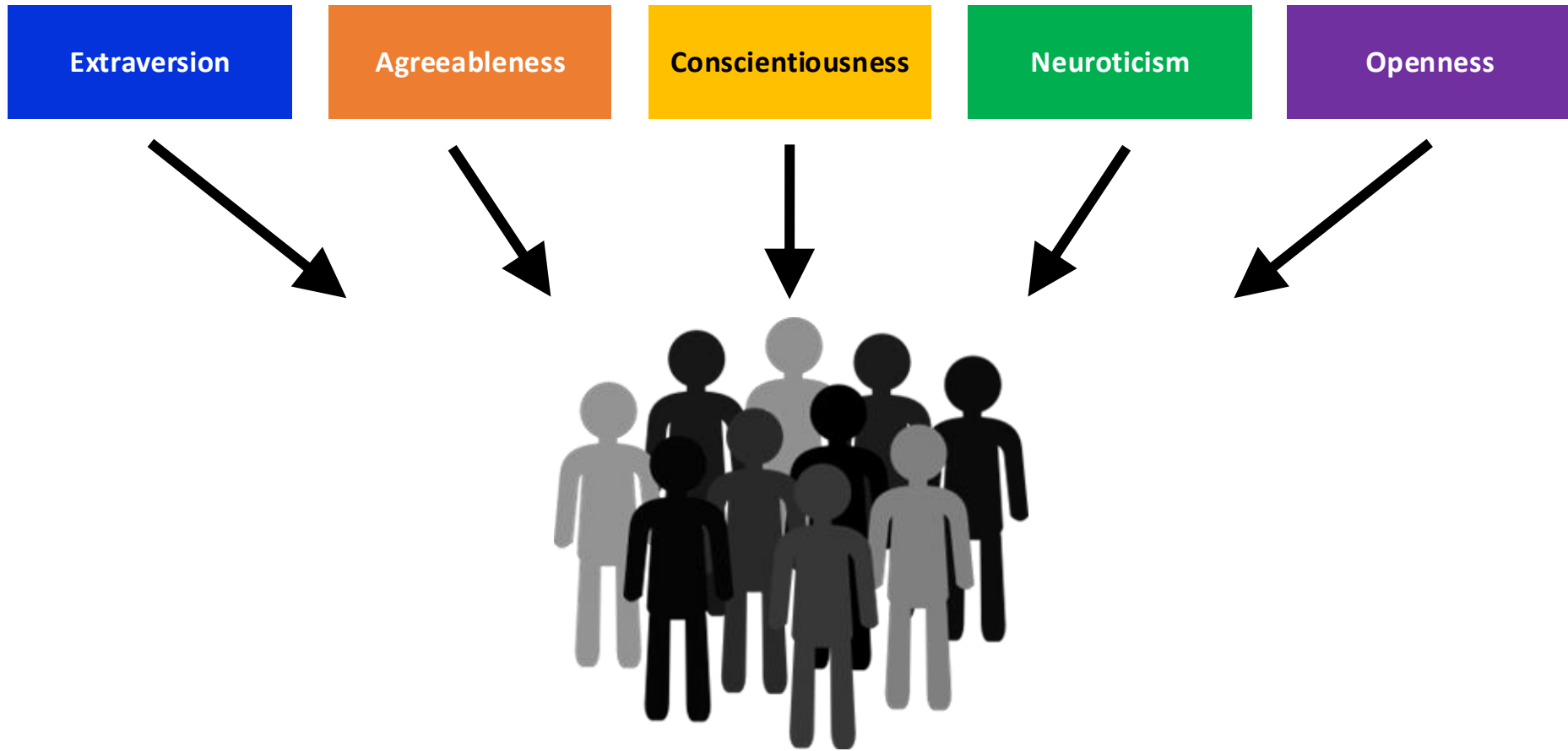


12:07 PM · Sep 17, 2024 · 275 Views

What is personality?

Personality is what personality tests test.

(Jack C. Wright, personal communication, 2013)



**Population-Level
Between-Person
Variable-Centered**

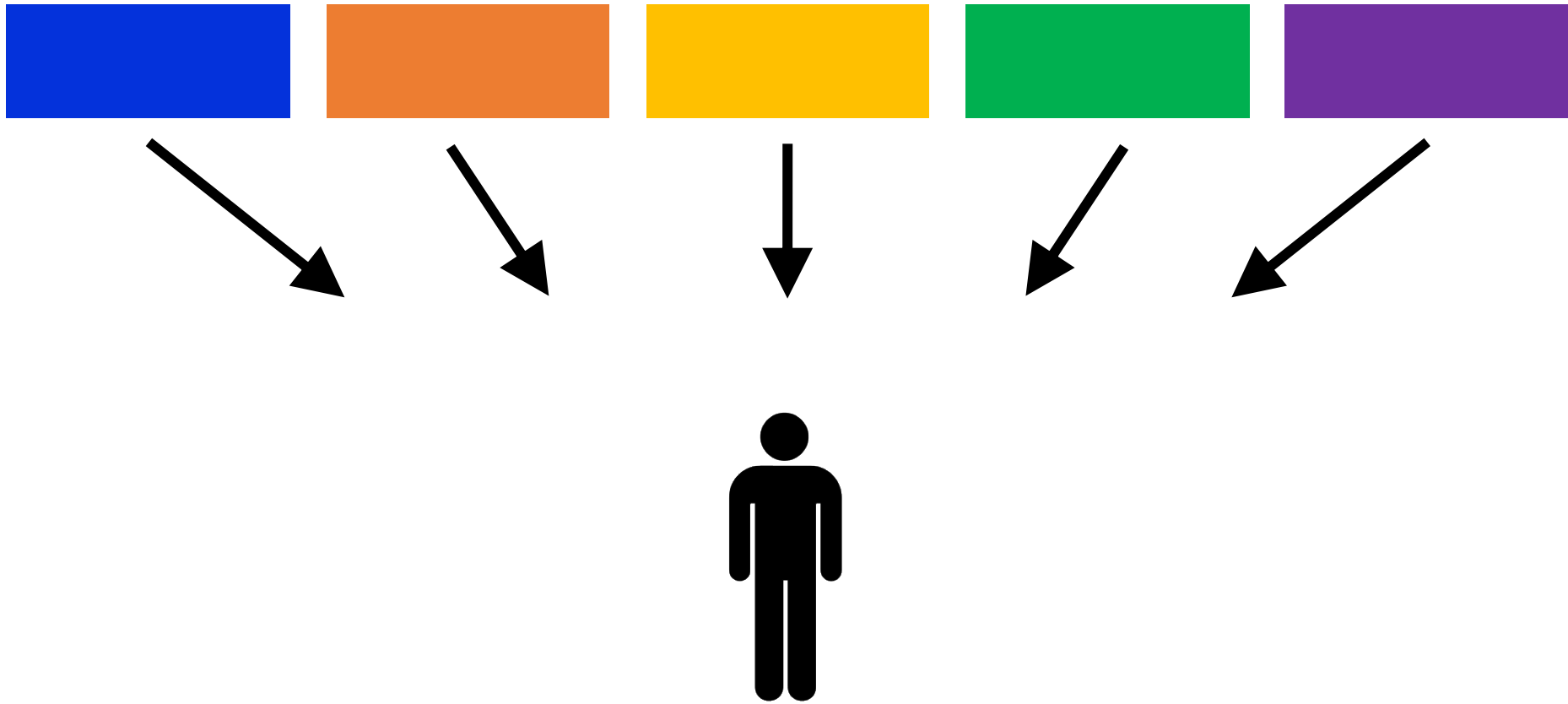
What is personality?

“Personality is the **dynamic organization** within the individual of those **psychophysical systems** that determine his **unique adjustments to the environment.**”

(Allport, 1937, p. 32)



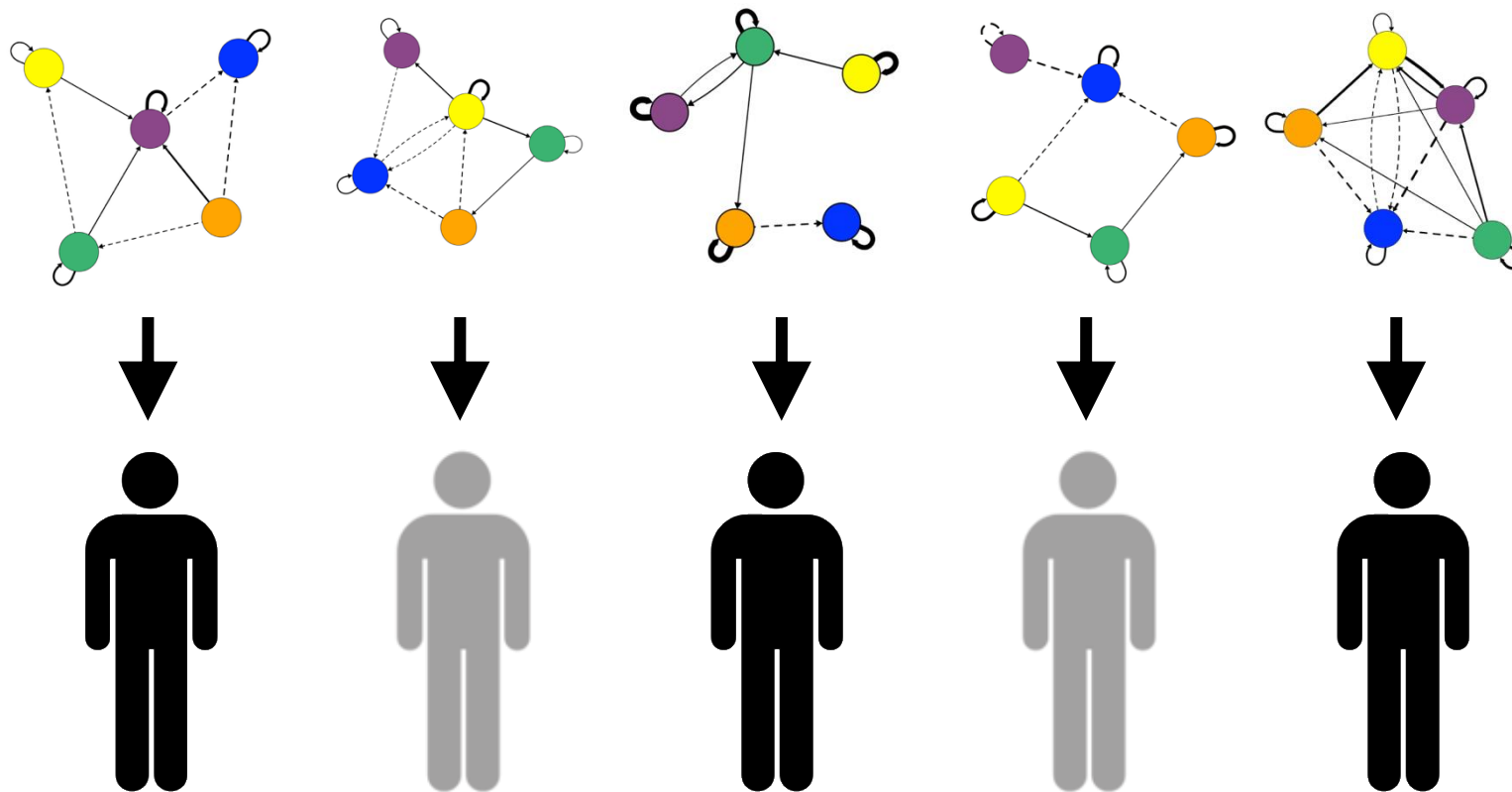
e.g., Allport, 1937, 1961, 1968



**Idiographic
Person-Specific**

N = 1

e.g., Beck & Jackson, 2020a, *JPSP*; 2020b, *CDPS*



Idiographic
Person-Specific
N = 1

e.g., Beck & Jackson, 2020a, *JPSP*; 2020b, *CDPS*

What is personality?

Personality as a person-specific complex system

What is personality?

**Personality is a person-specific complex,
nonlinear dynamic system**

“We do not propose a more dynamic trait model; we propose a model in which traits are not the primary mode of explanation” (Beck et al., 2026, p. 24).

What I don't have time to talk about 😞

History of person-specific and systems approaches in personality

13 criteria we argue personality definitions must meet (and why a system's framework does)

A conceptual and definitional primer on dynamic and complex systems

A bunch of empirical examples

Epistemological, formal, and logical arguments for a person-specific approach

A clear future agenda

What is personality?

**Personality *is* a person-specific complex,
nonlinear dynamic system**

**What is
“characteristic?”**

Persons are whole

**What makes
personality cohere?**

What is personality?

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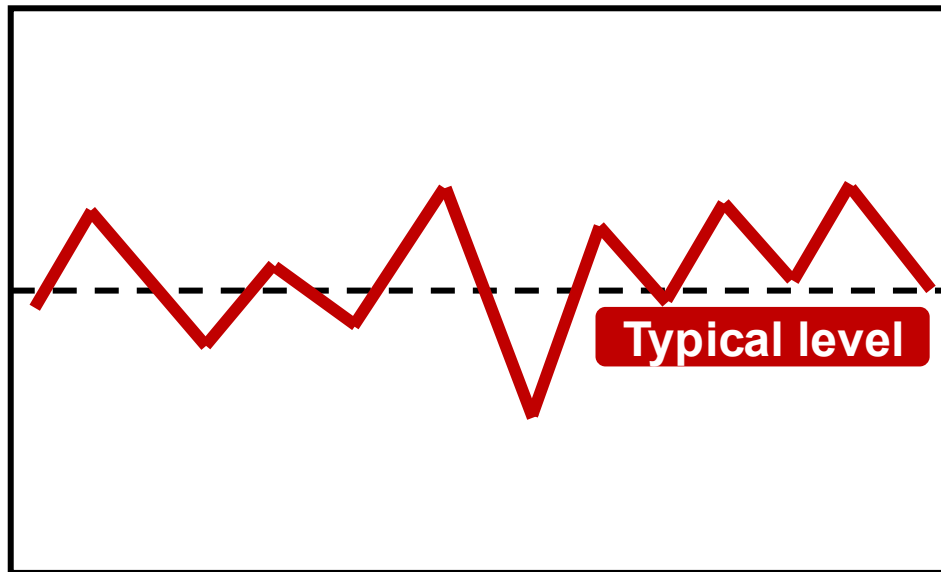
What is “characteristic” about characteristic patterns?

“Personality refers to those **characteristics** of the person that account for **consistent patterns of feelings, thinking, and behaving.**”

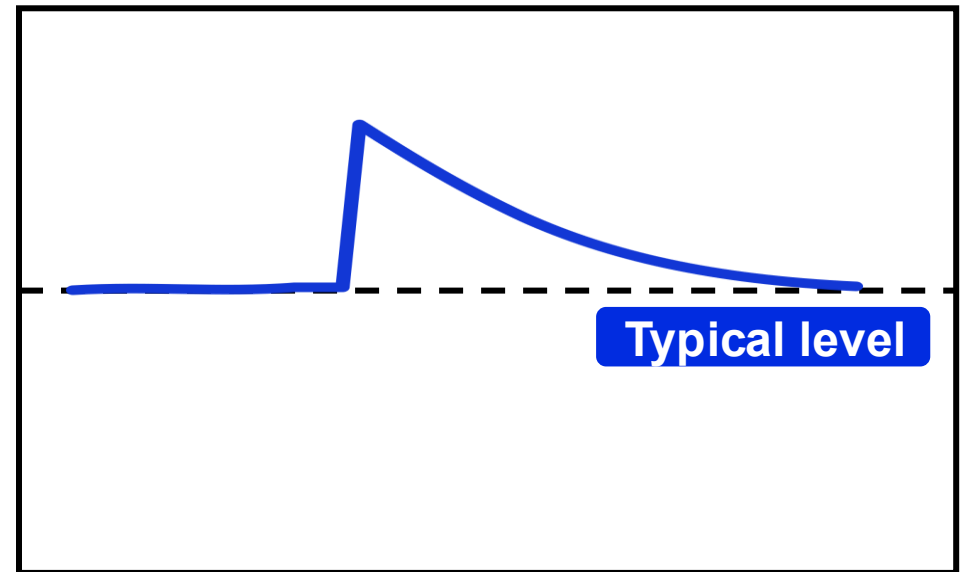
(Pervin, Cervone & John, 2005, p. 6)

What is “characteristic” about characteristic patterns?

**Characteristic as
tendencies**

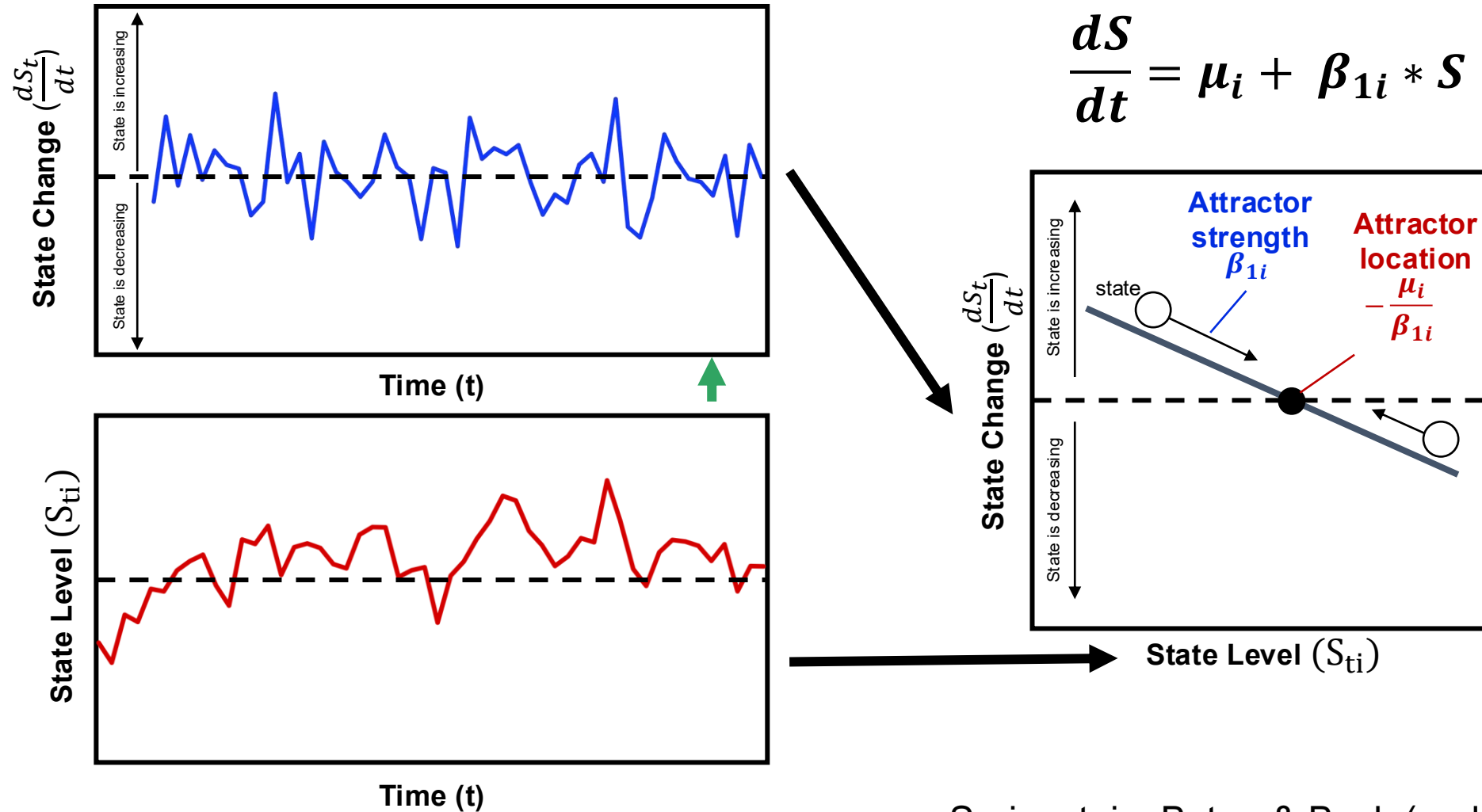


**Characteristic as
reactivity**

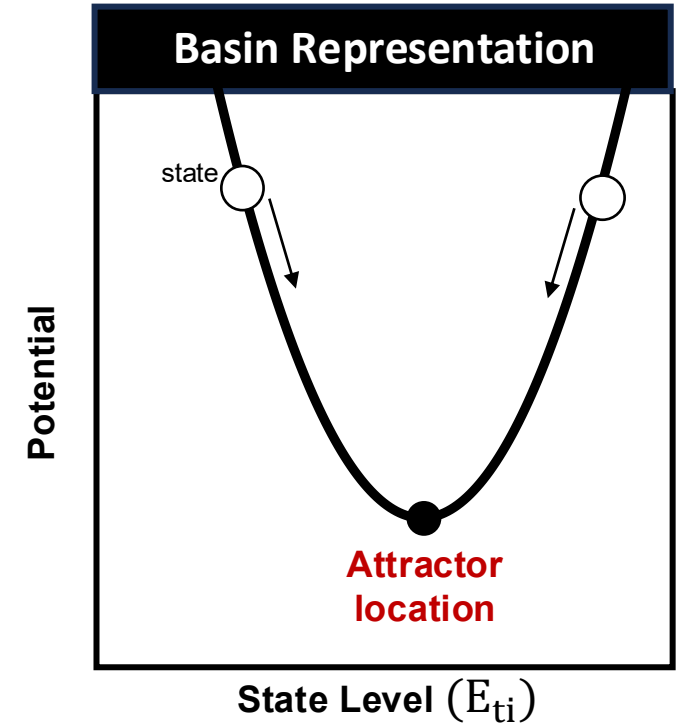
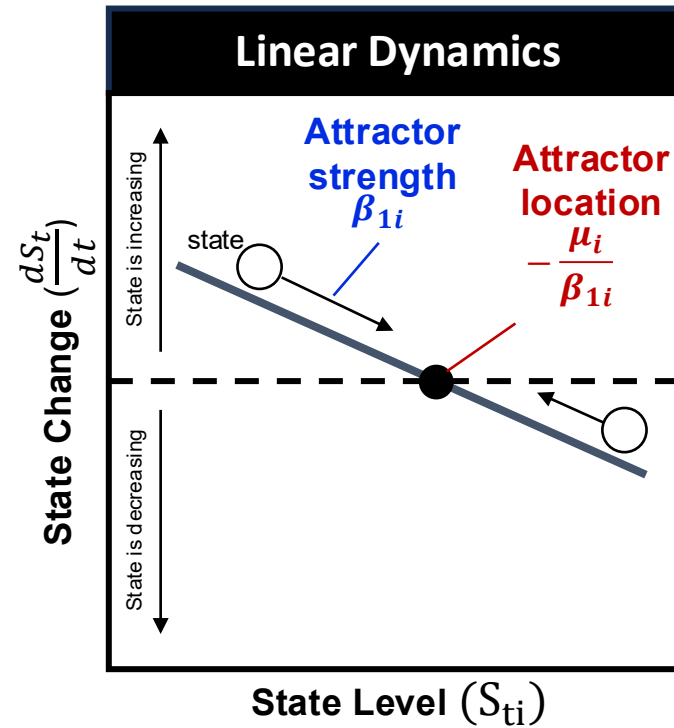
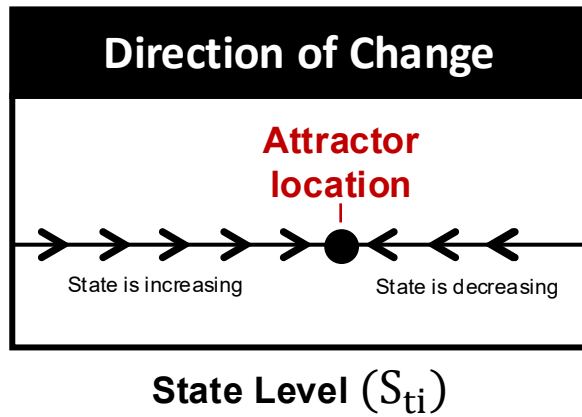


What is “characteristic” about characteristic patterns?

Mapping State Trajectories onto Rate-of-Change Dynamics



What is “characteristic” about characteristic patterns?



What is “characteristic” about characteristic patterns?

A dynamic systems representation allows for tendency (attractor location) and reactivity (attractor strength) to be jointly considered in the same framework, allowing what is characteristic in personality to be both.

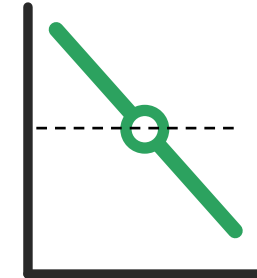
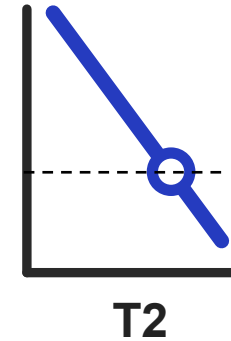
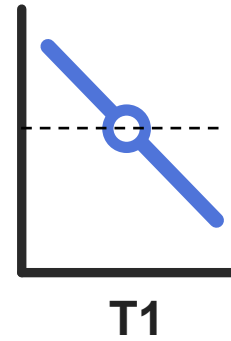
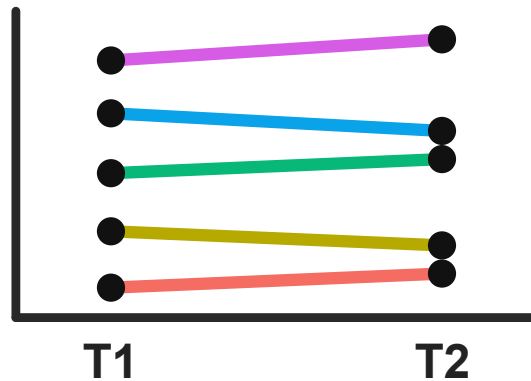
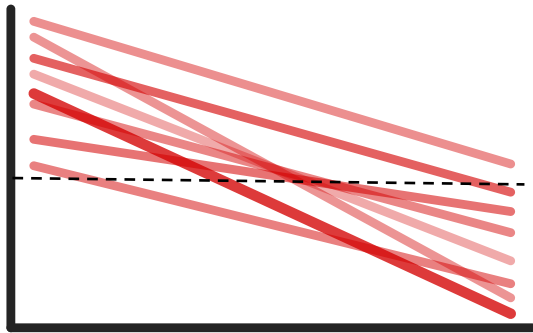
What is “characteristic” about characteristic patterns?

**Heterogeneous
across people**

Stable

Changing

Consequential



What is personality?

**Personality *is* a person-specific complex,
nonlinear dynamic system**

**What is
“characteristic?”**

Persons are whole

**What makes
personality cohere?**

What is personality?

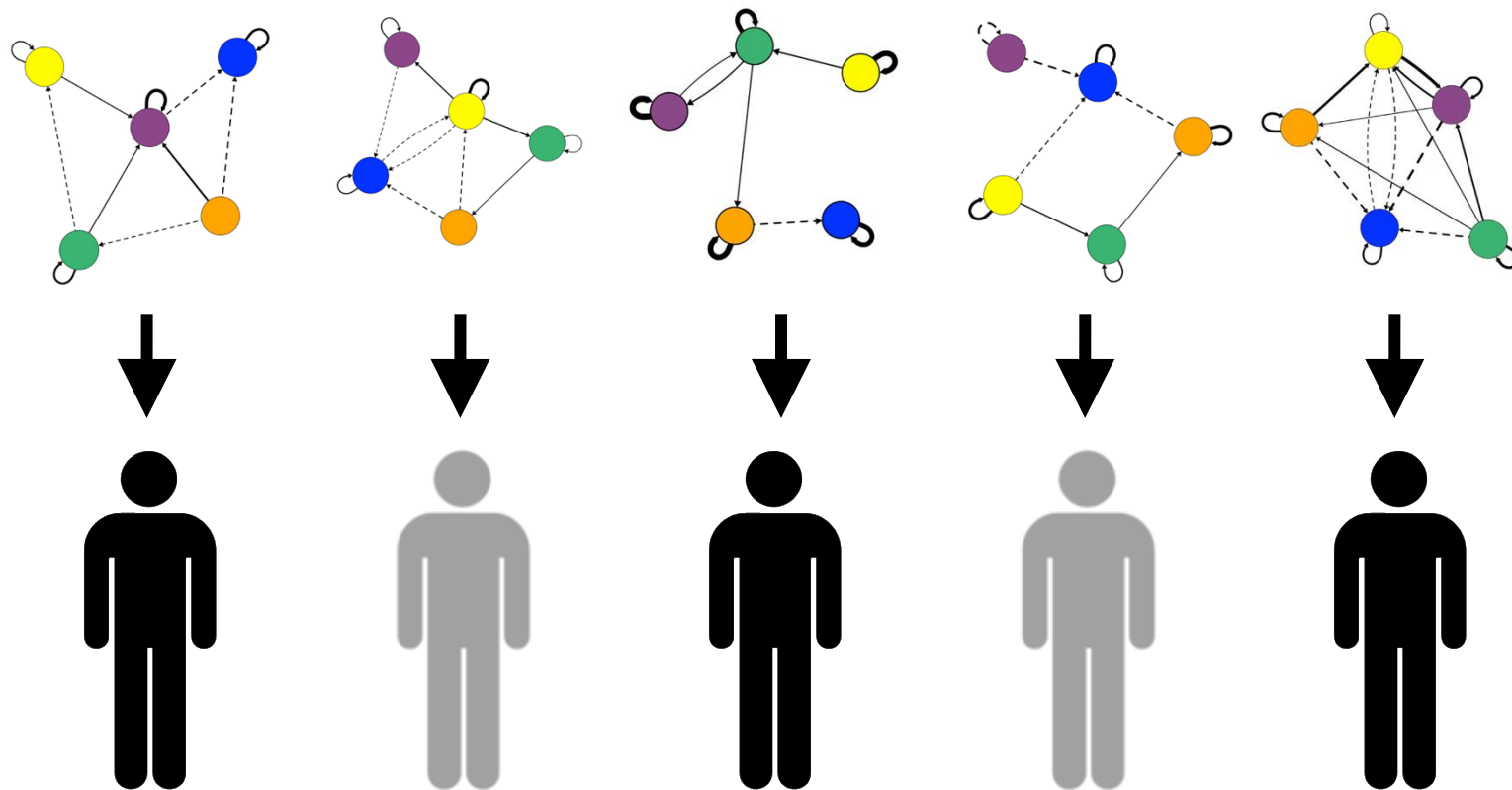
**Personality *is* a person-specific complex,
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Persons are whole

Persons are organized wholes: Their multivariate structures differ across people yet show meaningful stability over time.

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What makes personality cohere?

“Let me repeat this question, for it is the one that more than any other has haunted me over the years. What makes the system cohere in any one person?”

(Allport, 1960; p. 308).



A systems answer: self-organization and emergence within a multilevel system

Self-Organization and Emergence



What makes personality cohere?

Population-Level
Patterns

Population-level structure and differences

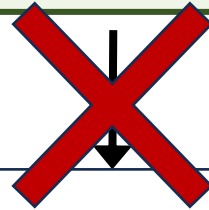
E

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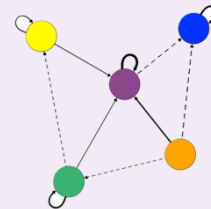


PERSON-SPECIFIC SYSTEM (i.e. within a person)

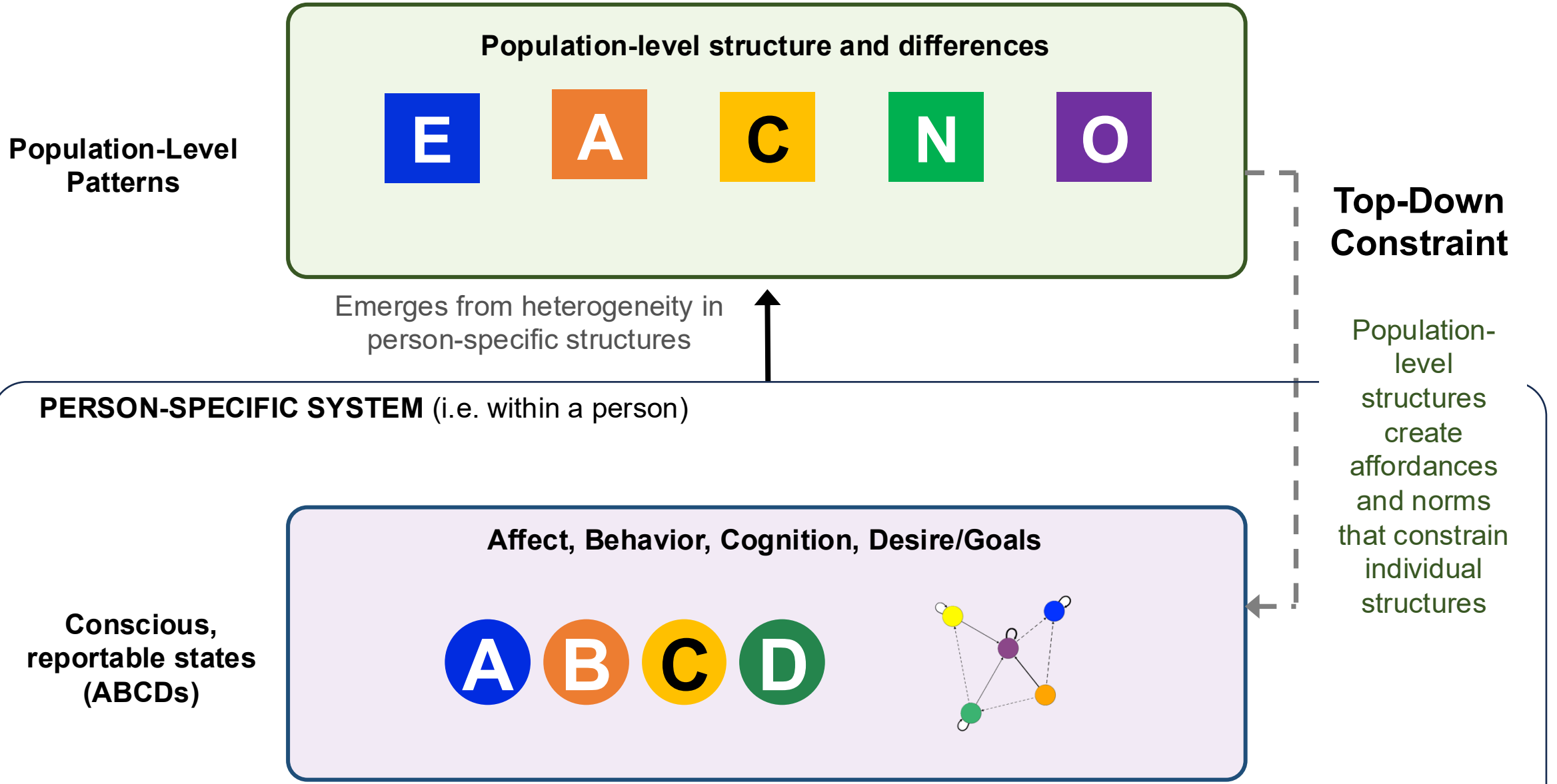
Conscious,
reportable states
(ABCDs)

Affect, Behavior, Cognition, Desire/Goals

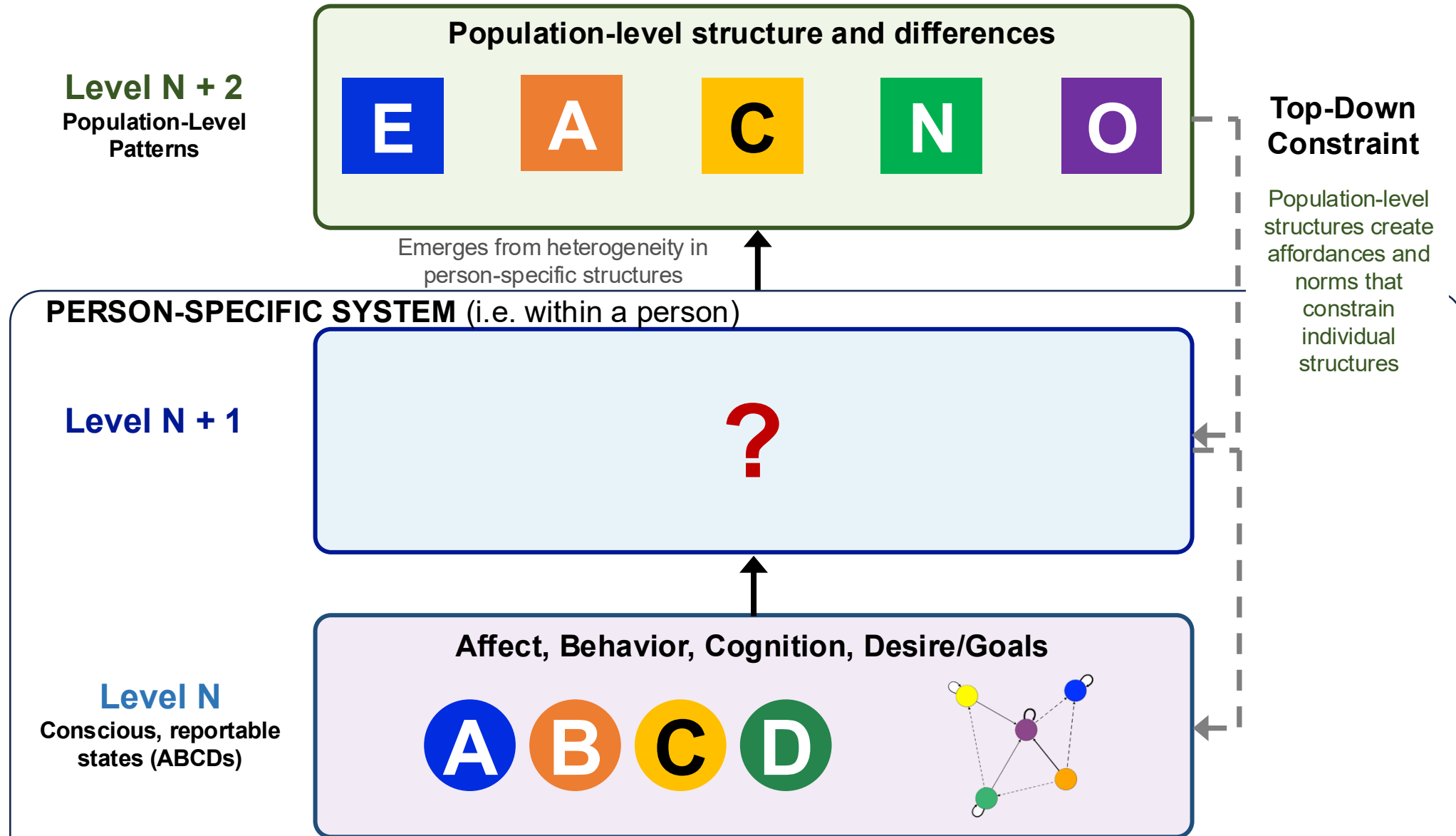
A B C D



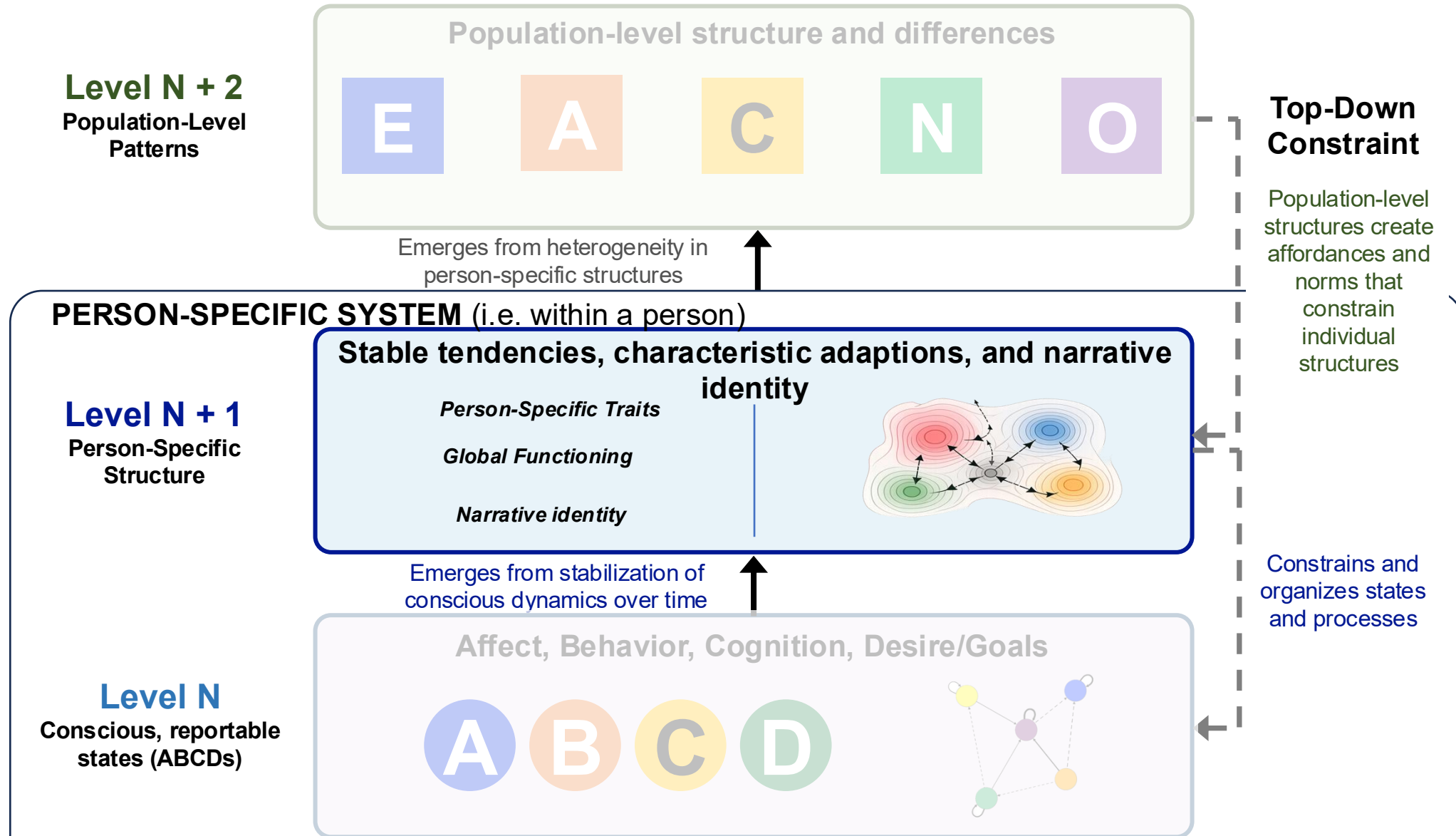
What makes personality cohere?



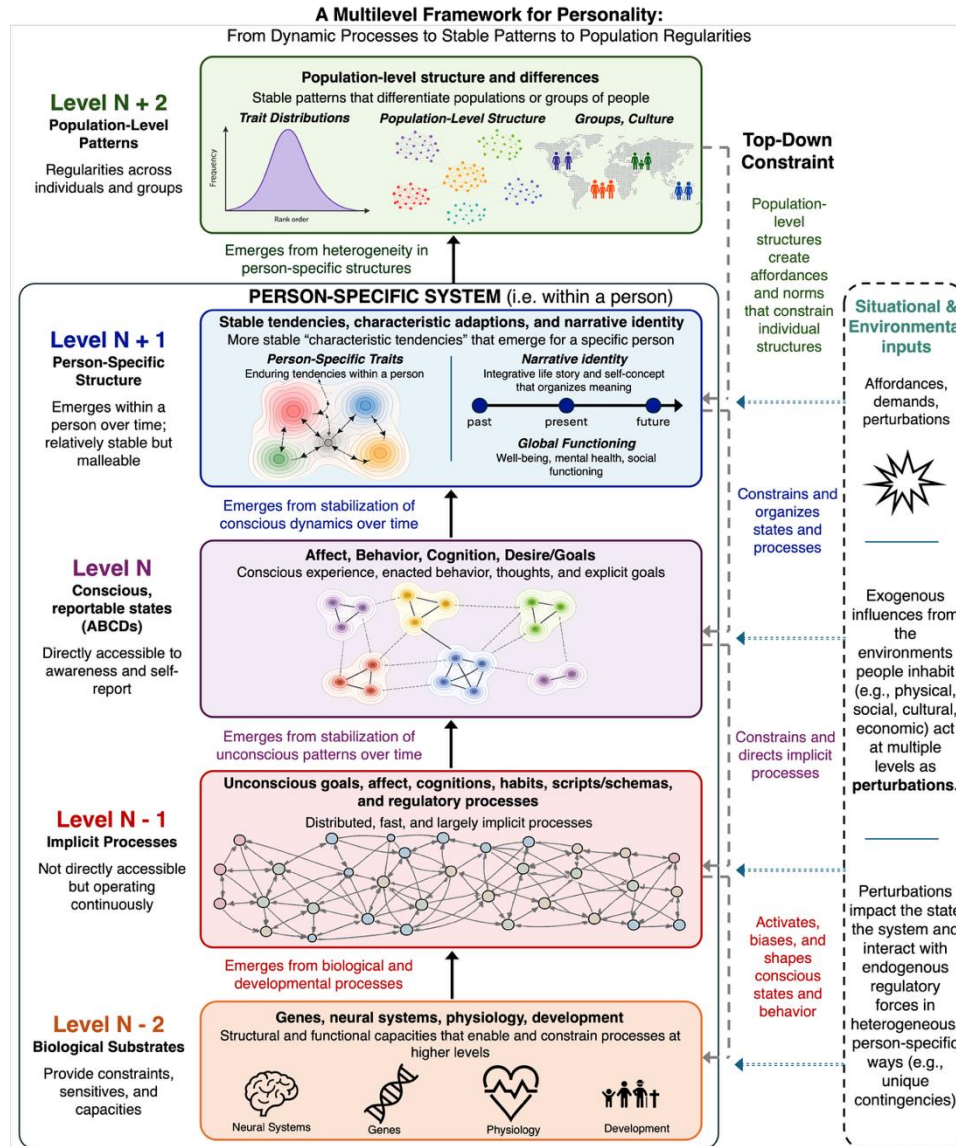
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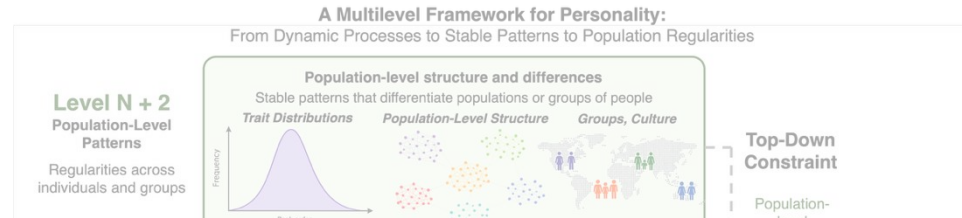
What makes personality cohere?



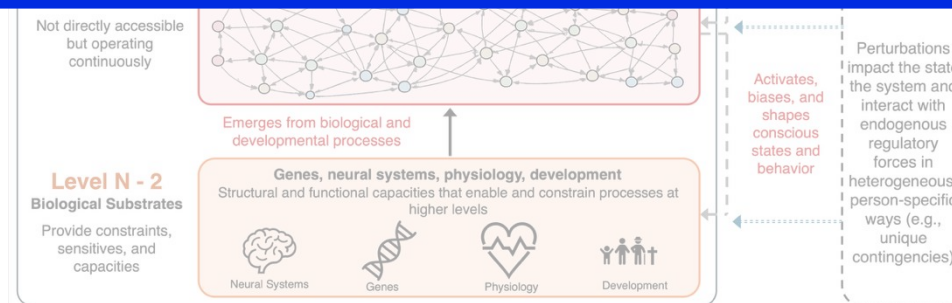
What makes personality cohere?



What makes personality cohere?



Personality coherence is emergent: Person-specific patterns self-organize across levels and, once established, constrain the dynamics from which they arise.



What is personality?

**Personality *is* a person-specific complex,
nonlinear dynamic system**

**Personality is
tendency and
reactivity**

Persons are whole

**Personality is
characterized by
self-organization
and emergence**

Roadmap to Bottom-Up Integration

From person-specific dynamics to population-level structure

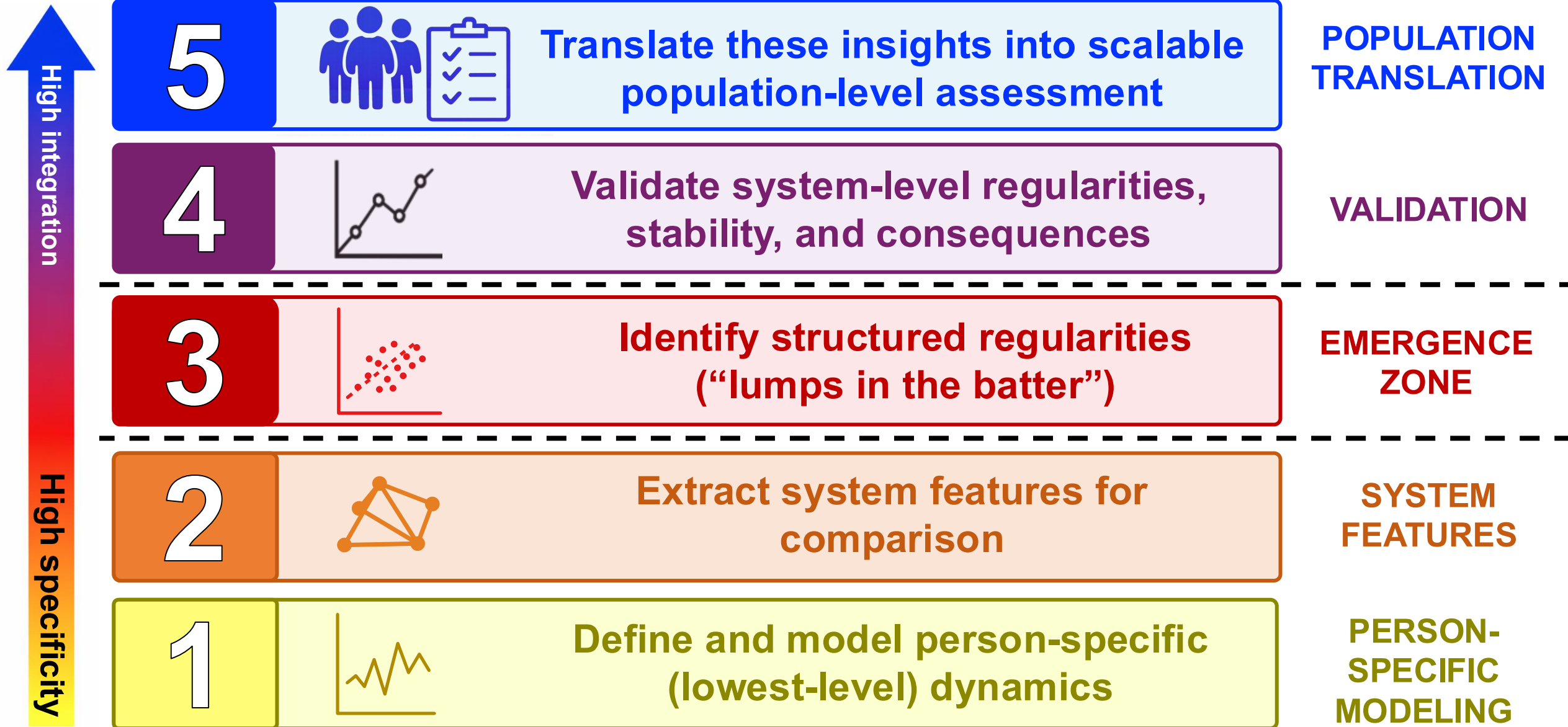
“Instead of growing impatient with the single case and hastening on to generalization, why should we not grow impatient with our generalizations and hasten to the internal pattern?”

(Allport, 1961, p. 84)



Roadmap to Bottom-Up Integration

From person-specific dynamics to population-level structure



PERSONALITY
Science

SPECIAL ISSUE • CALL FOR PAPERS

Taking the Person Seriously: Person-Level Inferences and Bottom-Up Integration



Deadline: August 16

Full info here!



PECORINO

PERSONALITY CONSORTIUM FOR RESEARCH IN
IDIOGRAPHICS & NOMOTHETICS

Acknowledgements



Collaborators

(on presented this paper)

Dr. Le Vy Phan
Dr. Nick Modersitzki
Colin J. Lee
Dr. Elizabeth U. Long
Dr. Adam T. Nissen
Dr. Cory T. Lewis



Slides



Paper



National Institute
on Aging

Contact



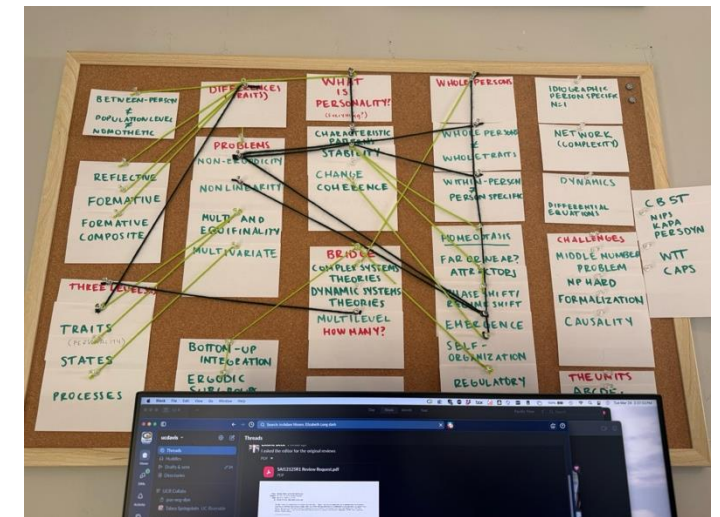
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Funding Sources: National Institute on Aging RF1AG088206 (PI: Beck) and T32 AG00030-3, National Science Foundation BCS-2336406 (co-PI Beck) and BCS-1125553